

Instructions for Data Extraction

CAL FIRE Palisades Fire Incident Reports Dataset

1. Purpose of the Task

The goal of this project is to **compile structured data from CAL FIRE incident update reports** into a master Excel dataset, using any data scraping tools and techniques you choose.

Each update report describes wildfire response activities during the **Palisades Fire (January–February 2025)**. The compiled dataset will later be used to analyze:

- disaster response timelines
- resource deployment
- interorganizational collaboration
- network governance during disasters

It is extremely important that the information be **accurate, complete, and copied exactly as written**.

2. Data Source

All reports must be collected from the official CAL FIRE incident updates page:

[Palisades Fire Incident Updates \(CAL FIRE\):](https://www.fire.ca.gov/incidents/2025/1/7/palisades-fire/updates)

(<https://www.fire.ca.gov/incidents/2025/1/7/palisades-fire/updates>)

This page lists **all update reports released during the incident (344 reports in total)**, from the first report on January 7, 2025 through later updates as the fire progressed.

Each update page contains structured sections such as **Incident Facts** (name, status, location, containment, etc.) and narrative sections like **Situation Summary** describing ongoing response conditions.

You may access the reports either by:

- viewing them directly on the webpage
- downloading the report page as a PDF
- copying information directly from the website

Use whichever method you find most convenient.

3. Materials Provided

You will receive:

1. **The Excel template dataset**
 - o This file already contains **two completed example reports**.
2. **The two example reports**
 - o These correspond to the two completed rows in the Excel template.

Please study these examples carefully before beginning. They demonstrate how the information from a report should be transferred into the spreadsheet.

4. Basic Dataset Structure

Each **report** = **one row** in the Excel spreadsheet.

Each **type of information** = **one column**.

Example structure:

Report_Sequence	Report_ID	Report_Date	Report_Time	Situation_Summary	Containment	Personnel
001	PF_202501071106	01/07/2025	11:06 AM	text from report	0%	200

When processing a new report, **add a new row at the bottom of the spreadsheet**.

5. Core Data Entry Rules

Rule 1 — Copy information verbatim

All text must be copied **exactly as written in the report**.

Do NOT:

- summarize
- paraphrase
- interpret
- abbreviate

Example:

Correct:

Los Angeles County Fire Department

Incorrect:

LA County FD

Rule 2 — Do NOT change numbers or formatting

Do not modify:

- numbers
- percentages
- punctuation
- capitalization

Example:

Correct:

23,448

Incorrect:

23448

Data cleaning will be done later.

Rule 3 — If a report does NOT include information for a column, leave the cell blank

Not every report includes all sections.

If a column exists in the template but the report does not contain that information:

leave the cell blank.

Do NOT enter:

0
N/A
None
Unknown

Blank cells indicate that the information **was not reported in that update.**

Rule 4 (Extra Credit)— If a report includes NEW information not currently in the template, add a new column

Later reports may contain **additional sections or new information types.**

If you encounter information that:

- appears in the report
- does not fit into any existing column

then you should:

1. **Add a new column to the spreadsheet**
2. Name the column using the section title from the report
3. Copy the text exactly as written

Example:

If the report includes a section titled:

Utility Restoration

and no such column exists:

Add a column called:

Utility_Restoration

Then enter the verbatim text.

If you add a new column, **please specify it in the readme file stating for which file at**

<https://www.fire.ca.gov/incidents/2025/1/7/palisades-fire/updates>

, which section information does not have a corresponding column, thus you must add.

6. Sanity Check (Quality Verification)

A. Periodic Spot Checks (Every 10–15 Reports, optional)

Depending on your process, it is recommended that after completing approximately **10–15 reports**, you select **one report from that batch** and conduct a verification check manually. (See below for what to check on).

B. Final Dataset Verification (Required)

After all assigned reports have been entered, conduct a **final comprehensive check** of the dataset.

This should include:

1. Random report verification

Select **5–10 reports randomly** and compare them with the original reports to ensure that all information was transferred correctly.

2. Structural consistency check

Review the dataset to confirm:

- Report_Sequence numbers follow chronological order
- Report_ID values match report dates and times
- new columns (if any were added) are used consistently

3. Scan for common errors

Check for:

- accidental abbreviations
 - modified numbers or percentages
 - misplaced text in incorrect columns
 - sections that appear in reports but are missing from the dataset
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Important Note

If you discover an error during a spot check, review the **previous few reports entered before that check** to ensure the same issue did not occur repeatedly.

Catching systematic errors early helps maintain the reliability of the entire dataset.

Final Reminder

Even small pieces of information in the reports may later become important variables for analyzing wildfire response and coordination across agencies. Therefore, it is essential that all information be **captured completely and exactly as written**.

Accuracy and consistency are the highest priorities.